The Actor's Nightmare

By Christopher Durang

Basically an empty stage with a few set pieces on it. George Spelvin wanders out. He wanders downstage, looking very confused. Enter Meg, with clipboard and master script. She is looking at the clipboard and doesn't notice George at first.

GEORGE: Oh, I'm sorry. I don't know how I got in here.

MEG: *(Looking up at the sound of his voice and xing to him)* Oh, thank goodness you're here. I've been calling you. An awful thing has happened. Eddie's been in a car accident, and you'll have to go on for him.

GEORGE: Good Heavens, how awful *(Xing a few step SL)* . . . who's Eddie *(Xing back)*?

MEG: Eddie. *(He looks blank.)* Edwin. You have to go on for him . . . He's been in a car accident.

GEORGE: Yes, I understood that part. But what do you mean "go on for him"?

MEG: You play the part. Now I know you haven't had a chance to rehearse it exactly, but presumably you know your lines and you've certainly seen it enough.

GEORGE: I don't understand. Do I know you?

MEG: George, we really don't have time for this kind of kidding. Half-hour. (Exits)

GEORGE: My name isn't George, it's . . . well, I don't know what it is, but it isn't George.

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INTRODUCTION

We've all had dreams spurred by anxiety . . . Perhaps the lawyer who gets up to begin his opening statement and can't find his papers? Or when he does, they're in German? The emergency doctor who goes to make an incision and his instruments have turned to rubber? Still, it seems the cruelest forms of these nightmares are those that dog the poor actor. The Actor's Nightmare by Christopher Durang

GEORGE: Am I an actor? I thought I was an accountant. Any why does everyone keep calling me George? *(Enter Dame Ellen Terry from SR. She Xs to George.)*

ELLEN: Hello, Stanley. I heard about Edwin. Good luck tonight. We're counting on you. *(Starts off L)*

GEORGE: Wait. What play are we doing?

ELLEN: *(turning towards him)* Very funny, Stanley. "Checkmate" by Samuel Beckett. You know, in the garbage cans. You always play these jokes, Stanley, just don't do it onstage. Well, good luck tonight. I mean, break a leg. Did you hear? Edwin broke both legs! *(Exits SL, laughing)*

GEORGE: I've never heard of "Checkmate". *(Enter Meg SR, looking at her watch.)*

MEG: George, get into costume. We have 15 minutes.

GEORGE: I better just go home. *(Takes off his pants.)* I didn't mean to do that.

MEG: George, stop that. *(Indicating SL)* Go into the dressing room to change. Really, you keep this up and we'll bring you up on charges.

GEORGE: But where is the dressing room?

MEG: George, you're not amusing. *(Indicating again, more angrily and exasperated)* It's that way. And give me those. *(Takes his pants)* I'll go soak them for you. Now go get changed. The call is 5 minutes. *(Pushes him off towards dressing room SL, Xs back SR)* 5 minutes, everyone. 5 minutes. Places.

VOICE: Ladies and gentlemen, may I have you attention please? The management wishes to remind the audience that the taking of photographs is strictly forbidden by law, and is dangerous as it may disorient the actor. Thank you.

GEORGE: Where are you going? Don't go! *(Smiles out at audience. Enter Sarah SR dressed as Queen Gertrude.)* Oh, good to see you.

SARAH: O Hamlet, speak no more. These words like daggers enter in mine ears. No more, sweet Hamlet.

GEORGE: Very well. What do you want to talk about?

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SARAH: *(melodramatically)* No more! *(Exits SR)*

GEORGE: Oh don't go! *(Pauses, smiles uncomfortably at the audience)* Maybe someone else will come out in a minute. *(Pause)* Of course, sometimes people have soliloquies in Shakespeare. *(The lights change suddenly to a dim spot center stage. George is not standing in the spot.)* Oh dear. *(He moves awkwardly to the spot, decides to do his best.)* To be or not to be, that is the question. *(Doesn't know anymore.)* Oh maid! Line. Line! Ohhhh . . . Oh, what a rogue and peasant slave am I. Whether tis nobler in the mind's eye to kill oneself, or not killing oneself, to sleep a great deal. We are such stuff as dreams are made on; and our lives are rounded by a little sleep. *(Spot light moves and George moves into it.)* I pledge allegiance to the flag of the United States of America and to the republic for which is stands, one nation, under God, indivisible, with liberty and justice for all. Line. Line! Line! *(Explaining)* When you call for a line, the stage manager normally gives you your next line to refresh your memory. Line! The quality of mercy is not strained. It droppeth like a gentle rain upon the place below when we have shuffled off this mortal coil. Alas, Poor Yorick- I knew him well. Get thee to a nunnery- Line!- Nunnery. *(Irritated)* Line! *(Apologetic)* I'm sorry. This is supposed to be Hamlet or Private Lives or something and I keep rattling on like a maniac- I really do apologize. I just don't recall attending a single rehearsal. I don't know what I was doing. And also you came here to see Edwin Booth and you get me. I really am very embarrassed. Sorry. Line! *(Singing)* A, b, c, d, e, f, g, h, i, j, k, l , m, n, o, p, q, r, s, t . . . It's a far, far better thing I do then I have ever done before . . . It's a far far better place I go to than I have ever been before. *(Ellen enters SL, dragging 2 large trash cans. She puts them side by side, gets in one.)* Oh good- Are you Ophelia? Get thee to a nunnery! *(She points to the other garbage can, indicating he should get in.)* Get in? Okay. *(He does.)* This must be one of those modern Hamlets.

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ELLEN: Nothing to be done. Pause. Pause. Wrinkle nose. *(Wrinkles nose.)* Nothing to be done.

GEORGE: I guess you're not Ophelia.

ELLEN: We'll just wait. Pause. Either he'll come, pause pause pause, or he won't.

GEORGE: That's a reasonable attitude. Are we, on a guess, waiting for Godot?

ELLEN: No, Willie. He came before and was an awful bore. Yesterday he came. Garlic on his breath, telling a lot of unpleasant jokes. He was just dreadful, pause, rolls her eyes upward *(she rolls her eyes).*

GEORGE: Well, I'm sorry to hear that. Pause. So who are we waiting for?

ELLEN: We're waiting for Lefty.

GEORGE: Ah. And he is a political organizer or something, I seem to recall?

ELLEN: Yes, dear, he is a political organizer. He's always coming around saying to get involved, get off your behinds and organize, fight the system, do this, do that, uh, he's exhausting, he's worse than Jane Fonda. And he has garlic breath, just like Godot, I don't know which of them is worse, and I hope neither of them ever comes here again. Blinks left eye, blinks right eye, closes eyes, opens them *(does this).*

GEORGE: So we're not really waiting for anyone, are we?

ELLEN: No, dear, we're not. It's just another happy day, pause, smile, pause, picks bug from head *(does this).*

GEORGE: Do you smell something?

ELLEN: *(under her breath)* That's not your line. Willie doesn't have that many lines. *(Louder)* Oh, Willie, how talkative you are this morning!

GEORGE: There seems to be some sort of muck in the bottom of this garbage can.

ELLEN: Mustn't complain, Willie. There's muck at the bottom of everyone's garbage can. Count your blessings, Willie. I do. *(Counts to herself, eyes closed.)* One. Two. Three. Are you counting, Willie? I'm up to three. Three is my eyesight. *(Opens*

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her eyes.) Oh my God, I've gone blind. I can't see< Willie. Oh what a terrible day. Oh dear. Oh my. *(Suddenly very cheerful again.)* Oh well. Not so bad really. I only used my eyes occasionally. When I wanted to see something. But no more!

GEORGE: I really don't know this play at all.

ELLEN: Count your blessings, Willie. Let me hear you count them.

GEORGE: Alright. One. Two. Three. That's my eyesight. Four. That's my hearing. Five, that's my . . . MasterCard. Six, that's . . .

ELLEN: Did you say God, Willie?

GEORGE: No.

ELLEN: Why did you leave the monastery, Willie? Was it the same reason I left the opera?

GEORGE: I have no idea.

ELLEN: I left the opera because I couldn't sing. They were mad to have hired me. Certifiable. And they were certified shortly afterward, the entire staff. They reside now at the Rigoletto Home for the mentally Incapacitated. In Turin. Pause. Tries to touch her nose with her tongue *(does this.)*

VOICE: Ladies and Gentlemen, may I have your attention please? At this evening's performance, the role of Sir Thomas More, the man for all seasons, normally played by Edwin Booth, will be played by Georg Spelvin. *(Enter Meg with a few costume touches but otherwise in her stage manager garb. She is carrying a script.)*

MEG: Oh father, why have they locked you up in this dreadful dungeon, it's more than I can bear. If you don't give in to King Henry, they're going to cut off your head. *(Sudden alarming crash of cymbals. The Executioner enters USL and Xs CS and stops.)*

GEORGE: I've got to get out of here.

MEG: He's over here. And he'll never give in to the king.

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GEORGE: No, no, I might. Quick, is this all about Anne Boleyn and everything?

MEG: Yes and you won't give in because you believe in the Catholic Church and the infallibility of the Pope and the everlasting life of the soul.

GEORGE: *(to Meg)* I don't necessarily believe in any of that. *(To Executioner)* Oh sir, there's been an error. I think it's fine if the King marries Anne Boleyn. I just want to wake up.

MEG: Oh don't deny God, father, just to spare our feelings. Mother and I are willing to have you dead if it's a question of principle.

GEORGE: I don't think the Pope is infallible at all. I think he's a normal man with normal capabilities who wears gold slippers. I thought about joining the monastery when I was younger, but I didn't do it.

ELLEN: *(waking up from a brief doze)* Oh, I was having such a pleasant dream, Willie. Go ahead, let him cut your head off, it'll be a nice change of pace. *(Executioner wheels out chopping block.)*

GEORGE: That blade looks very real to me. I wasn't to wake up now. Or change plays. A horse, a horse, my kingdom for a horse!

EXECUTIONER: Sir Thomas More, you have been found guilty of the charge of High Treason. The sentence of the court is that you be taken to the Tower of London, thence to the place of execution, and there your head shall be stricken from your body and may God have mercy on your soul. *(Meg helps George out of the garbage can.)*

GEORGE: Alright, I'm sorry I didn't go to the monastery, maybe I should have, and I'm sorry I giggled during church in the 3rd grade, but I see no reason to be killed for it.

EXECUTIONER: Do I understand you right? You wish to reverse your previous stand on King Henry's marriage to Anne and to deny the Bishop of Rome?

GEORGE: Yes, yes, YES! *(He rises)* I could care less. Let him marry eight wives.

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EXECUTIONER: That's a terrible legacy of cowardice for Sir Thomas More to leave behind.

GEORGE: I don't care!

EXECUTIONER: I'm going to ignore what you've said and cut your head off anyway, and then we'll all pretend you went to your death nobly. The Church needs its saints and school children have got to have heroes to look up to, don't you all agree?

GEORGE: Yes, yes, I can feel myself waking up now. The covers have fallen off the bed and I'm cold, and I'm going to wake up so that I can reach down and pull them up again.

EXECUTIONER: Sir Thomas, prepare to meet your death.

GEORGE: Be quiet, I'm about to wake up.

EXECUTIONER: Sir Thomas, prepare to meet your death.

GEORGE: I'm awake! *(Looks around him)* No, I'm not.

EXECUTIONER: Sir Thomas, prepare to meet your death.

GEORGE: Line! Line!

MEG: You turn to the Executioner and say, "Friend, be not afraid of your office. You send me to God."

GEORGE: I don't like that line. Give me another.

MEG: That's the line in the script, George. Say it.

ELLEN: Say it, Willie. It'll mean a lot to me and to generations of school children to come.

EXECUTIONER: Say it.

GEORGE: They say you can never dream your own death, so I expect that I'll wake up just as soon as he starts to bring down the blade. So perhaps I should get it over with.

MEG: Say the proper line, George. *(George kneels down.)*

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GEORGE: Friend, be not afraid of your office. *(Executioner raises axe.)* You send me to God. *(Executioner raises axe higher to bring it down.)*

EXECUTIONER: *(In darkness)* Behold the head of Sir Thomas More.

(Everyone bows except George who is dead on the floor. Everyone else does curtain call and leaves. After the stage is clear, George gets up dazed and looks around. Looks out at the audience and leaves.)

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AWARD HISTORY

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